



GRIMES COUNTY COMMISSIONERS COURT

SPECIAL MEETING

OFFICIAL MINUTES — FRIDAY, AUGUST 14, 2026

The Grimes County Commissioners Court met on Friday, August 14, 2026, at 9:00 A.M. Members Present: County Judge Joe Fauth, Commissioner Chad Mallett, Commissioner David Tullos, Commissioner Michael Raska, Commissioner Phillip Cox. County Judge Joe Fauth called the meeting to order.

1. **Discuss and review the Grimes County FY 2027 proposed budget. — Joe Fauth III**

After reading the agenda items, County Judge Joe Fauth stated that Public Comment Forms have been submitted and Statute 551.007 of the Texas Government Code does allow that the Public has statutory right to address a government body on an item posted on the agenda. Commissioner David Tullos requested a Point of Order. Mr Tullos stated he consulted with the County Attorney to ensure the Court was in compliance with Open Meetings Act, because there was not notification allowing Public Comments through the published agenda, therefore, Public Comments are not allowed at this meeting. Mr Tullos further stated that these individuals can be recognized to speak during the discussion on the budget itself. Judge Fauth, once again, stated Statute 551.007. Statutory rights requires a government body to allow public testimony on items listed on an open meeting agenda. Commissioner Phillip Cox stated that the Judge referenced it as Public Comments. This is a budget discussion and they are treated differently. The Commissioners Court engaged in extensive discussion of the Grimes County FY 2027 proposed budget, with multiple county employees and officials addressing compensation disparities and budget priorities. Chris Accord, justice of the peace for Precinct 1, spoke on behalf of his clerical staff, noting that he had sought raises for his employees for three years without success. He referenced Judge Fauth's proposed balanced budget that included a \$4 per hour raise for all employees with no additional tax burden on taxpayers, and he urged the court to approve it, observing that Commissioners' salaries had increased by 20.7 percent over the past three years while hourly employees had received far less. Commissioner David Tullos challenged Accord's characterization, noting that justices of the peace had also solicited raises in previous budget hearings and that Accord's own salary increase exceeded what the Commissioners had received. Commissioner Phillip Cox disputed whether a balanced budget had been submitted, characterizing it as incomplete and deficit by millions of dollars, though Judge Fauth clarified that the proposed budget included \$2 million in contingency funds from SpaceX money that could address much of the shortfall. Additional county employees addressed the court, emphasizing that a \$4 per hour raise should apply county-wide rather than to law enforcement alone. Jamie Weeks, the 911 addressing coordinator, highlighted the county's rapid growth driven by the TeraFab project and the workload demands on county staff, urging investment in all employees to retain experienced workers and attract qualified applicants. Chief of Staff Patti Ermis presented a petition signed by over 100 county employees requesting equitable pay increases across all departments, arguing that inflation affects all workers equally and that differentiated raises fracture morale and undervalue non-law-enforcement staff. Benjamin Napier of the Road and Bridge department, Richard Gore, an assistant construction supervisor, Crystal Jarvis, executive assistant to Judge Tuck McClain, and IT Director Gregg Cannon all spoke in support of

county-wide raises. Kirk Cloyd, development services technician, referenced the 2023 classification and compensation study by H&R compensation consultants that had identified pay disparities and noted that Grimes County's impending growth would make competitive compensation essential for retention. Elections Administrator Rachel Walker supported law enforcement compensation while expressing concern that the loss of a county-wide \$4 raise now applied only to certain positions, which she said created morale problems and made recruitment and retention difficult. County Attorney Megan Barcak and County Auditor Jessi Murphy presented two pay scale options for law enforcement personnel that recognized prior experience and adjusted minimum and maximum salaries, with Barcak clarifying that these options applied to all employees required to hold a TCOL certification, including dispatchers, jailers, and deputy constables. Chief Deputy Martha Smith stated her preference for option one, citing retention and recruitment concerns, and noted that deputies had expressed they would leave if offered higher-paying positions elsewhere. Commissioner Phillip Cox emphasized that law enforcement personnel who carry weapons and face greater occupational hazards deserve different compensation consideration than administrative staff, and the court discussed whether certain non-TCOL-certified employees in the district attorney's office and others should be included in any pay adjustment. The discussion extended to early voting locations, SB 22 fund usage, and various technical budget matters, with Commissioner David Tullos advocating for a no-new-revenue tax rate while still addressing employee compensation where possible.

Action: Motion by Commissioner David Tullos to Recess until the county attorney can be present to address the Open Meetings Act question in person so the Court doesn't knowingly violate the Open Meetings Act. Seconded by Commissioner Phillip Cox Failed (2–3–0).

Voting Yea: Commissioner David Tullos, Commissioner Phillip Cox

Voting Nay: Commissioner Chad Mallett, Commissioner Michael Raska, County Judge Joe Fauth

- 2. Consider and take action to propose a tax rate and take a record vote on proposed tax rate. If proposed tax rate will exceed the voter-approval tax rate or the no new revenue tax rate (whichever is lower), take record vote and schedule a public hearing. — Joe Fauth III**

County Judge Joe Fauth introduced the tax rate discussion and explained that the proposed budget process had created a chicken-and-egg situation, as he lacked certified revenue numbers when preparing his initial proposal. County Auditor Jessi Murphy requested that budget discussion be deferred until after the tax rate was established. County Judge Fauth moved to propose a tax rate of 0.40, representing a reduction from the current rate of 0.423077, along with specific employee salary recommendations; however, County Attorney Megan Barcak clarified that the motion for tax rate needed to address only the rate itself. Commissioner David Tullos proposed an alternative rate of 0.39, which failed on a vote. Tullos then moved for a compromise rate of 0.395, seconded by Commissioner Cox. During extensive discussion before the vote, County Judge Fauth presented comparative salary data from other Texas counties showing that Grimes County's compensation packages were competitive or below average, and advocated for meaningful salary increases. Commissioner Chad Mallett raised concerns about capital project funding and the need to reserve adequate funds from the expected ten-million-dollar payment. Commissioner Phillip Cox questioned the methodology and noted prior issues with merit-based pay distribution. County Attorney Megan Barcak and others stressed the importance of

establishing clear, consistent evaluation criteria. The court discussed the concept of foregone revenue and how the county could potentially recapture unused tax capacity within three years. GCAD Shannon Sanders was called to the podium to explain the mechanics of foregone revenue and the voter approval rate. The discussion covered the balance between providing tax relief to citizens while maintaining sufficient revenue for employee compensation and future capital projects.

Action: **Motion by Judge Joe Fauth to propose a 2027 tax rate decrease from the current rate of 0.423077 to 0.40, showing a tax rate reduction of 0.023077. No second. Motion failed.**

Action: **Motion by Commissioner David Tullos to propose a 2027 tax rate of 0.39 per \$100 valuation. Seconded by Commissioner Phillip Cox. Failed (2-3-0)**

Voting Yea: Commissioner David Tullos, Commissioner Phillip Cox

Voting Nay: Commissioner Chad Mallett, Commissioner Michael Raska, County Judge Joe Fauth

Action: **Motion by Commissioner David Tullos to propose a 2027 tax rate of 0.395 per \$100 valuation. Seconded by Commissioner Cox. Carried (4-1-0)**

Voting Yea: Commissioner David Tullos, Commissioner Phillip Cox, Commissioner Michael Raska, County Judge Joe Fauth

Voting Nay: Commissioner Chad Mallett

A motion by Commissioner David Tullos to adjourn the meeting was made, seconded by Commissioner Michael Raska. Carried. The meeting adjourned at 11:42 AM.

THE OFFICIAL MINUTES OF THE GRIMES COUNTY COMMISSIONERS COURT ON August 14th, 2026, ARE HEREBY APPROVED.

County Clerk, Barbara Kimich